Jan Sangh', lost by over 69,000 votes a by-election in Jaunpur that had been necessitated by the death of the sitting MP.[110] The same trend was replicated in Punjab and Haryana, areas full of Partition refugees, where the party lost all the three seats it had gained.

In contrast to the Jan Sangh, Mehta observed with dismay that the Communist Party retained more than 75 per cent of the seats it had won in the previous election. Not a single Jan Sangh MP, including Vajpayee and Madhok, until that point had been elected to Parliament thrice. In contrast, the Communists had several three- or four-time MPs: men like A.K. Gopalan, Hiren Mukerji, Renu Chakravarty, Indrajit Gupta, S.M. Bannerji, Anandan Nambiar and Sarju Pande. In August 1967, Mehta and a group of Jan Sangh workers met Vajpayee in Bombay when he came to address workers in Matunga. They presented their thesis, along with facts and figures. Vajpayee gave them a 'patient hearing', accepted their findings and said, '*ab aisa nahin hoga* [this will not happen from now on]'.[111] The 1967 SVD alliances briefly changed Jan Sangh fortunes. Yet, in the 1969 mid-term elections to state assemblies in UP, Punjab and West Bengal, once again the party lost 79 per cent (117 of 149) of the seats it had won previously. All the Jan Sangh ministers were defeated in UP in 1969, as were its state president and key leaders in Punjab, all from seats they had won earlier. Furthermore, it lost its urban base in key cities—Amritsar, Jullunder, Gurgaon, Ambala, Lucknow, Bhiwani, Karnal, Pathankot and so on.

So why was the Sangh failing to hold on to its political gains, unlike the communists? This conundrum greatly animated the senior leadership of the Sangh and the pages of *Organiser* in the late 1960s. Party leaders identified several factors.

They argued that the Congress, the party in power, concentrated its firepower against the Jan Sangh, focusing on wresting back seats wherever the latter advanced. Besides, the Jan Sangh was handicapped by the fact that it did not have enough leaders with stature, *Organiser* editor K.R. Malkani argued in the magazine's February 1969 issue. This was a 'essentially a matter of length in public life'. Party leaders speculated that the wave of anti-Congressism that had driven Opposition politics had subsided. At the state level, senior leaders felt that the Jan Sangh had been